The Center for Media and Public Affairs conducted a comparative study of the Vietnam War and the First Gulf War through the lens of the media, defining the former as “the Living Room War” and the latter as “the Instant Replay War.” During the Gulf War, for the first time in history, the world could watch the crisis and the war unfolding live before their eyes. This war had a second front: the struggle for control over television content, the struggle between the Pentagon and the media. This was the story of the American effort to prevent a second Vietnam and to try to influence America’s future in the global village that was increasingly being shaped by the media. It was the story of an independent opposition media that found itself in conflict with the American citizen, who expected the media to support “the good guys.” The media lost this battle. The Pentagon succeeded in blocking and controlling the media’s endless thirst for more information.

During and after the war, opinion polls were conducted by the Times Mirror Company, which owned major publications including the *Los Angeles Times* and *Newsday.* According to these polls, eight out of every ten Americans rated the media’s performance during the war as good. An even higher number viewed the censorship imposed on the media as being justified and approved of the “pool” method (in which free access to combat zones and security information was given, not to any journalist who requested it, but only to those representatives of the media selected by the Pentagon, who then distributed their stories and broadcasts to all media outlets) that was employed during this war. A high percentage of respondents said that they would have approved even more severe censorship than that which was actually imposed. Similar polls conducted after the war produced even higher numbers of those who approved censorship. The traditional distribution of responses to public opinion polls in the United States on the question of whether to allow the media to publish stories that they believe should be brought to the attention of the public or whether to censor when it comes to preserving national security has always been 50-50. But in the post–Gulf War polls the distribution was two to one in favor of censorship. On the margins of these polls were, of course, also the extremists, from the camp of General Schwarzkopf, the commander of all the coalition forces in Iraq, who accused the media of helping and encouraging the enemy, to the left-wing circles who hurled the opposite accusation—that the media acted as the “cheerleaders” of the war.